

The Meaning of “Son of God”

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The subject of my paper is: what does it mean when the Bible says Jesus is the Son of God? Who is Jesus? Is Jesus God? I want to explain the meaning of the phrase “Son of God” and explain all the Bible verses that pertain to this phrase. The telos of the paper is to have us to be able to say, “Amen, I believe that Jesus is the Son of God (or Son of the Living God as Peter professed), and I know what Son of God means.” As we will see later in this paper, Son of God is actually a phrase that is in Psalm 2:7. We see the phrase Son of God appear in Mark, as well as the other gospels, I believe. One of the biggest questions is: does ‘Son of God’ mean that Jesus is God? Also, when the Jews and Gentiles heard the phrase “Son of God” in the first century, what went through their head? And when they wrote it in the first century, what was their intent - their authorial intent in using this term? My thesis is: Son of God means that Jesus is God - meaning that he took on human nature and also has divine nature - and that this phrase is a fulfillment of several passages in the Old Testament, that also proclaim the Son of God.

The first source I will use is that of Van Dam, “The Messianic Office of David.”¹ According to this source, David is called God’s son, and he is appointed as nagid - or prince or leader over Israel. I believe nagid is a Hebrew term. As we learned from Bible interpretation class, David is a foreshadowing or a type that points to the promised Savior - Jesus Christ. Psalm 2 is where this reference occurs, and Psalm 2 is a “jubilant song exulting in the reign of the Lord,” according to Van Dam. Psalm 2:7 says “You are my Son; today I have begotten you” (2:7). Van says, “Sonship became effective immediately on David’s becoming king.” This is a very important point because if we look at Jesus’ baptism in Mark, we see that Jesus is declared to be the beloved Son. Therefore, we see that both David and Jesus are declared to be the Son at

¹ Van Dam, Cornelis. 2024. “The Messianic Office of David, Whom God Called His Son.” *Unio Cum Christo* 10 (1): 12–32.

a point in time later in life. However, I believe that David was not born as Son of God, and Jesus was the fulfillment of this phrase, so that he was Son of God before, now, and forever.

Another verse is 2 Sam 7:12–14; parallel 1 Chr 17:11–13:

I will raise up your offspring after you, who shall come from your body,
and I will establish his kingdom. He shall build a house for my name,
and I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever. I will be to him a
father, and he shall be to me a son. (2 Sam 7:12–14; parallel 1 Chr 17:11–13)

According to these verses, we see the phrase, “and he shall be to me a son.” This phrase, in 2 Samuel, is referring to Solomon. It says that Solomon shall be a son of God. But this sonship is not a perfect sonship, and is a type of Christ.

Another verse is: “And I will make him the firstborn, the highest of the kings of the earth” (Psalm 89:v. 27). As we can see from this verse, God is speaking of a ‘firstborn,’ which is a child of God. This is ultimately fulfilled by Jesus Christ. And when it says “highest of the kings,” we see a prophecy that applies to the Greatest, which is Jesus; and since it says “of the earth,” we see that this prophecy has not been yet fulfilled, and will be fulfilled when Revelation and the completion of this future prophecy occurs.

The next source is by Mortensen², titled “Seeing Is Not Believing: Faith in the Son of God.” This source says that, central to Mark, is the question of Jesus’ identity. To relate it to the thesis of this paper, I would like to point out that the phrase Son of God was used by Peter when he confessed Jesus. Jesus said that this identity was only revealed to him by the Father and that

²Mortensen, Hallur. 2023. “Seeing Is Not Believing: Apocalyptic Epistemology and Faith in the Son of God in Mark’s Gospel.” *Themelios* 48 (1): 92–105.

Peter is blessed to have known. This confession is unique and important because Peter identifies Jesus as the Son of God, which may have never occurred to anyone else previous to this.

The question was asked to all of the people who witnessed Jesus - who is this man? And many did not confess that he was the Son of God. In fact, there may have been many people who knew something was different and that he was great, but it wasn't clearly revealed to them that he was "the Son of God."

But to the blessed - for example, the disciples - it was alluded to in different ways. The first way was Mark 1:11 - the divine sonship at baptism, according to Mortensen. To review, at the baptism, the Father appeared and said, "This is my Beloved Son." This clearly shows that Jesus is the Son of God. But there is a question: he is the beloved son, but is he the Son of God?"

Can there be a difference between being a son and being the Son of God? What does Son of God exactly mean? I believe there is a difference, because the phrase "Son of God" has now taken on unique meaning, other than just the literal definitions of "Son" and "God." The phrase "Son of God" appears in Romans 1, where the Son of God is linked with "power." We see that the centurion in the Gospels also proclaims that "This must be the Son of God," after the crucifixion. Clearly, this phrase is linked with power, the resurrection, and possibly the same substance as God himself because he was born of the Holy Spirit, which is also declared to be God.

Thus, not any old Christian is "The Son of God." A Christian can be a beloved son, but not the same as the "Beloved Son" mentioned of Jesus. And a Christian is not born of the flesh, or the will of man, but of God (John 1), which makes us sons and daughters of God, but not "the Son of God."

Going back to the question of the identity of Jesus, we see that the second time Jesus is declared as the Son of God is at the transfiguration (9:7), where Jesus is glorified. The third is the crucifixion (15:39), according to Mortensen.

One question we may ask is: why do some fail to have faith in him? And the author replies that “their fear of him” (5:15) at the Gerasenes cause them to reject Jesus. And in Nazareth, “Jesus is amazed at their unbelief (6:5-6). They only “recognize him only as the ‘son of Mary’ (6:3) and not as the Son of God, which is how God identifies him (1:11; 9:7).” Thus, the author says it is not just sight alone (e.g. miracles) through which we can understand and profess the name, “Son of God,” it requires “revelation and a faith response.”

But the disciples had trouble too. In 4:40, Jesus asks, “Why are you afraid? Have you still no faith?” This verse is where Jesus commands the wind and waves (4:39), “but rather than faith, they had fear.”

The 3rd source is by Neumann³, “Remembering God’s Beloved Son.” We see that the phrase, “Son of God,” appears in the Old Testament, and the New Testament is referring and quoting the Old Testament in its usage of the term. Jer 38:20 includes God calling Israel his “beloved son.” According to Neumann, it “identifies Jesus as God’s royal son and the embodiment of God’s original son, Israel, in one breath.” We see that there are types and symbols, such as Israel being the son, and Jesus being the fulfillment. And we see the baptism as “a messianic anointing pointing toward a royal Christology.” We see that Jesus is a fulfillment of the Old Testament promises and of everything.

³ Neumann, James N. “Remembering God’s Beloved Son: Jeremiah 38:20 LXX and Mark 1:11.” *Journal of Biblical Literature* 142, no. 3 (December 31, 2023): 493–512. doi:10.15699/jbl.1423.2023.7.

The fourth source is by Sanders⁴, called “Hail the Incarnate Deity: Son of God.” This source mostly talks about how Christmas (the Incarnation) is not about just a birth of Savior, it is the incredible, royal, amazing, Word of God made flesh, where the human nature and the divine nature has been made one. Athanasius’ On the Incarnation says: “The incorporeal and incorruptible and immaterial Word of God comes into our realm, although he was not formerly distant. . . . But now he comes, condescending toward us in his love for human beings.”

When Jesus was born, we didn’t have the full solution. Thus, his birth “was precisely toward the goal of his death and resurrection.” They say, both the cross and the manger was hewn of the same wood. Athanasius’ book is actually more about the crucifixion and resurrection.

The birth of Jesus was the Son of God becoming the Son of Man - a combination of human and God. Epilambano, is a word in, “For surely it is not angels he helps, but Abraham’s descendants.” This word describes “Jesus reaching out to take hold of people...[like] an embrace or a hug.” We see the Jesus condescended to become like us, so that he can save us and make us like God.

In all of this, we see more clearly what the “Son of God” actually means. It means God’s nature, or the divine nature is in Jesus Christ. And the phrase “Son of Man,” shows that Jesus also had a human nature. The birth of Jesus is the unique point in history where theses two natures become one, and thus we do not cry out “Son Of God, do not destroy me!” Instead, we proclaim, “Son of God, you know me and are like me, can you help me, friend?”

⁴Sanders, Fred. “Hail the Incarnate Deity: Christmas Draws Our Attention Not Only to What the Son Does but Also to Who the Son of God Is.” Christianity Today 66, no. 9 (December 31, 2022): 62–68.

The final source is from Garner⁵, called “The Gospel of God Concerning His Beloved Son.” This source examines the phrase, “Son of God” as it appears in Romans 1. He views this phrase to refer to “their Davidic covenantal antecedent.” What this means is that this phrase points back to David. David was called The Son of God several times in Scripture, but this phrase is used by Jesus as the fulfillment of the type that David was. Thus, when Jesus is declared in power, he is declared to be the eternal Son of God “in power at his resurrection,” which is “his supreme concern” (his, referring to Paul the Apostle, who wrote Romans). “David’s greater Son is what yields saving effect for all the people of God, both Jews and Gentiles” (Garner).

What I find to be an interesting thing about this phrase in Romans, is that it seems to say that Jesus had two positions in history - the position of a servant before his resurrection, and the position of Son of God and full of power and authority after his resurrection. Thus, Garner says that this was “a two-stage enactment of Jesus’ messianic career, [while] ancient interpreters saw the verses as providing evidence for the two natures of Christ” (Garner). This was “two successive stages in His life,” according to Geerhardus Vos. “Christ came into being as to His sarkic existence, and He was introduced into His pneumatic existence,” which means that Christ first came in the flesh, and later was alive by the Spirit.

In conclusion, we see that Jesus was declared to be the Son of God in power, which shows that he has “all authority in heaven and on earth.” Surely, the title, Son of God, does not mean anything less than being the same substance as God himself. And thus, the Son of God shows that the Word that was God (John 1), became flesh and dwelt with us. And we see that through Athanasius’ book, that the human nature (Son of Man) was combined with the divine

⁵ Garner, David B. “The Gospel of God Concerning His Beloved Son: Further Steps on a Well-Traveled Text.” *The Westminster Theological Journal* 84, no. 2 (December 31, 2022): 257–79.

nature (Son of God). The phrase Son of God appears in the Old Testament in reference to David, and thus we see that David is a type pointing to Jesus Christ. We can learn this and that about the phrase, Son of God, but what does it mean to Christian life? We see that God did not grasp equality with God as something to take, but he condescended himself (kenosis) to be like us, and even more, to be our servant and foot-washer. We see that the Son of God is not some higher power that produces wrath on us no matter what because we are imperfect, but we see that the Son of God took our sin and became sin (Hebrews) so that we can become the righteousness of God (Romans). What wonderful news! We can love the Son of God, praise him, and be thankful for him. And we can partake in the divine nature and be in union with the Son of God and resurrect to everlasting life in joy and perfection.

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